Tackling the Potential Harms and Risks of Minors' Social Media Use: Strategies and Considerations for U.S. Policy

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Summary

Billions of people around the world today use social media platforms, millions of them likely minors. Indeed, children and youth have been some of the earliest, most ardent adopters of social media technology, many spending hours on social media daily. In recent years, the minors themselves, as well as caregivers, educators, academics, legal experts, medical professionals, policymakers, political leaders, and even tech workers have raised increasing concerns over the form, extent, and potential negative impact of our youngest people's social media use. Discussions of the potential risks and harms of social media use are now widespread in popular media and public forms, the halls of academia, and, as of most recent, the courts of justice. They all ask the same unresolved question: Are social media platforms running children into their demise?

This work focuses on the United States and takes a 'client's advocate' approach to local policy addressing the potential harms of minors' social media use, centering U.S. minors' well-being and perspectives. The introduction sections outline and review which social media platforms have been center of discussion, how they grew over time, and to what extent minors use them today. The next sections review the main concerns around minors' social media use and related data. Then follows a taxonomy of existing social media policy options and alternatives, and considerations and frameworks by which to evaluate them. The final section concludes with proposals for furthering the development of social media policy and constructive discussion among stakeholders.

In light of recently reported social media policy measures, such as Australia's social media ban for users under 16, it is likely other countries will also consider which social media policy strategies to adopt or adjust for their underage populations. This work primarily aims to help inform discussions and measures in the U.S., but also refers to and draws on considerations from abroad.

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Introduction

Last Wednesday, on March 25, 2026, a jury of peers ruled in favor of a young social media user who asserts that social media platforms have harmed her mental health since she began using them at age six.[1] The case, ruled in a court in Los Angeles County, California, has been garnering attention from major news outlets for months (see Figure 1). It was first filed in 2023 as one of the earliest cases of its kind in the United States; since then, thousands of other individual plaintiffs and U.S. school districts have filed similar lawsuits against social media companies.[2] The March ruling, touted as a 'bellwether trial,' may be built on and followed by many more lawsuits.

The plaintiff in the March ruling is just one among an enormous number of people who are using or have used social media as minors. Indeed, children and youth—persons under 18—have been among the earliest and most ardent adopters of the social media platforms that started cropping up in the late 2000s and early 2010s. Their most widely used platforms to date are TikTok, Facebook, Instagram, Snapchat, and YouTube,[3] alongside the rebranded platform X (previously Twitter), Reddit, and the emerging platform Threads (Pew Research Center, 2025, Common Sense Media, 2025, Ofcom, 2025). The companies running the platforms are among the most profitable and most highly valued in the world (see, e.g., Fortune, 2025). While each individual platform varies in the details of its design, function, and content, they all share core features: They facilitate interaction among users and enable them to create and share content (Boyd, 2014; Carr & Hayes, 2015).

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[1] See, e.g., https://www.nytimes.com/2026/03/25/technology/social-media-trial-verdict.html

[2] For a more detailed breakdown of filed legal cases, see, e.g., https://www.spencer-law.com/post/social-media-addiction-lawsuits-2026-kgm-trial-mdl-3047

[3] Spokespeople for YouTube have stated that it is a streaming platform, not a social media site (see, e.g., https://www.nytimes.com/2026/02/10/technology/youtube-social-media-addiction-trial.html). It is included as social media here, as users perceive it as such, researchers study it as such, and courts treat it as such, at least to date.

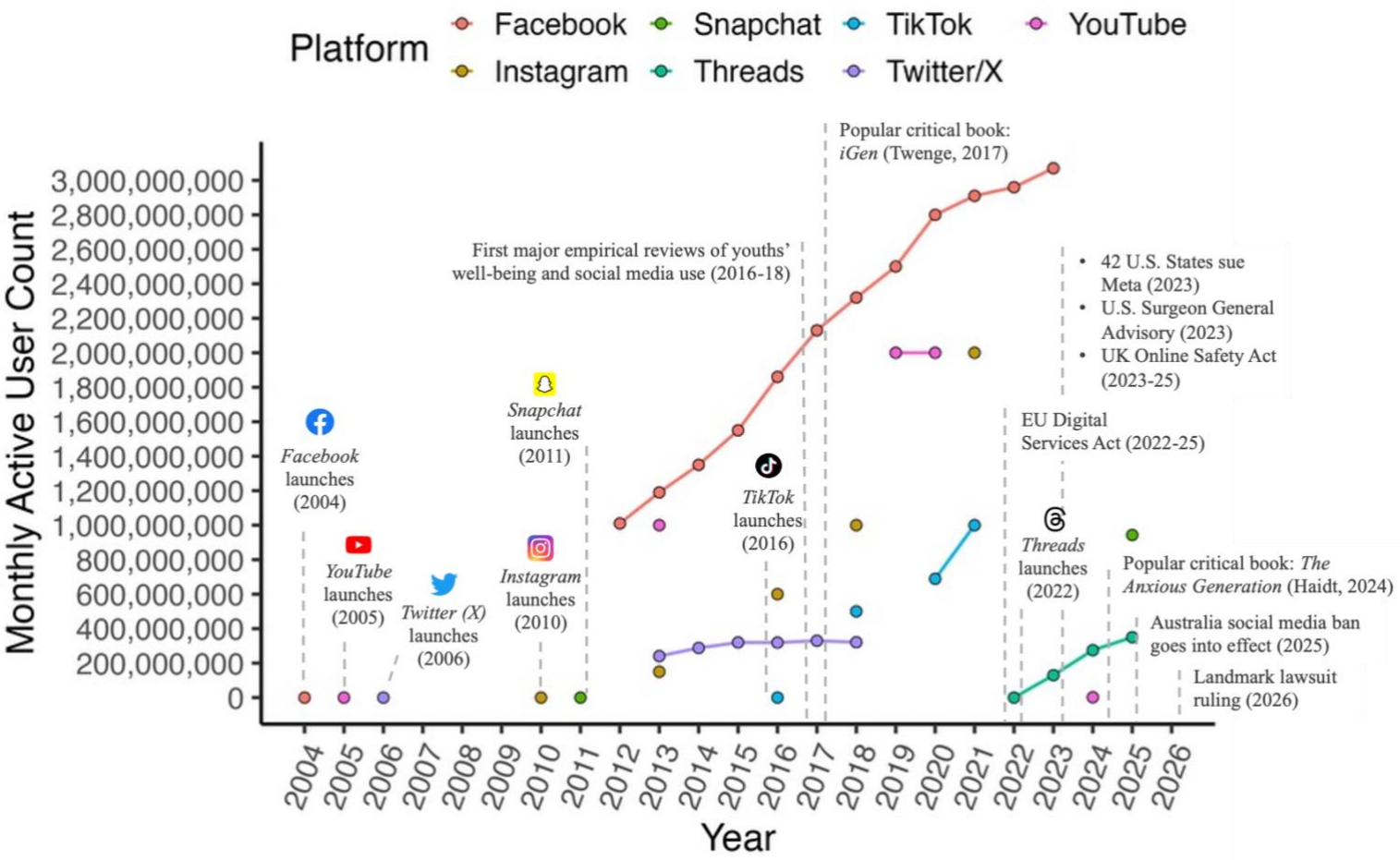
Fig. 1. Sample Headlines Across Major U.S. News Outlets Related to Minors' Social Media Use.

2026	Wake-up call: Landmark social media ruling exposes addictive algorithms as teen survey highlights dangers	Instagram chief denies social media can be 'clinically addictive' in landmark case	Social Media Addiction Trial Nears End. Society Long Ago Rendered Its Verdict.	Teen social media bans are destined to fail
2025	N/A	Lawsuit alleges social media giants buried their own research on teen mental health harms	Malaysia to Bar Children Under 16 From Social Media, Echoing Australian Ban	Even some teens say social media is hurting their mental health
2024	New Georgia law bans minors under 16 from using social media without parental consent	My social media is helpful and positive. Here is how yours can be, too	Researchers Say Social Media Warning Is Too Broad	Social media has become a grim fairy tale
2023	Nearly half of American teens 'constantly' on social media, study says	Social media: What the platforms are for and how they work	What Social Media Does to the Teen Brain	How addictive, endless scrolling is bad for your mental health
2022	Greg Gutfeld: Social media use can be like a bad smoking habit	A guide to parental controls on social media	It Was a Mistake to Let Kids Onto Social Media Sites. Here's What to Do Now.	N/A
2021	N/A	N/A	Worried About Your Teen on Social Media? Here's How to Help.	What parents need to know about social media for kids
	FOX NEWS	CNN	The New York Times	wp

Note. Headlines are based on a convenience sample by the author and are neither representative of all headlines nor the totality of news on this topic. "N/A" denotes no relevant headlines were found for the respective year. The depicted news sources are among the most viewed/read in the United States, including between 2021-2026 (Pew Research Center, 2025; Press Gazette, 2026). Notably, they are not the only major news sources; for instance, studies report that U.S. citizens increasingly turn toward social media platforms for news (Pew Research Center, 2026; Reuters Institute, 2025).

Minors and adults alike have been registering onto social media platforms at an extreme scale and pace. Facebook, one of the earliest and longest-standing social media platforms, had its total user count spring from zero to millions to 3 billion within just two decades. TikTok, launched in 2016, went from inception to a billion users around the world within just six years (see Figure 2).

Fig. 2. Social Media Platform User Counts and Major Events from 2004-2026.



Note. User count measured as Monthly Active Users, i.e., the number of unique users who interacted with the platform at least once in a month, averaged across the respective year. All data points represent user counts reported by primary sources (i.e., company reports and records; see https://github.com/adaniabutto/youthsocialmedia for all analysis code and references). No data from secondary sources or survey estimates were included. User counts are collapsed across adult and underage populations, as primary sources do not provide age breakdowns (but see sections below for related estimates). Major events were hand-selected by the author and are not exhaustive.

Minors' Social Media Use

Per their terms of service, the above social media platforms are open to all users above the age of 13; however, they do not allow minors under the age of 13 to sign up. Nevertheless, various sources have confirmed that children under 13 *do* sign up for and use social media platforms. Indeed,

research has documented that even most parents are aware of their children being on social media platforms before age 13, some even helping them sign up (Boyd, 2011; Nagata et al., 2025).

The companies operating social media platforms provide no publicly available data on their number of underage users. Granted, true age metrics are hard for them to obtain in the first place, given that minors under 13 need to report a false age to sign up. Minors above 13, too, may misstate their age for other reasons (e.g., to access adult content or additional functionalities such as direct messaging; Ofcom, 2022). However, select platforms have reported the number of under-13 accounts they removed in efforts to uphold compliance with existing regulations. TikTok, for instance, reported 90 million removals globally between October 2024 and September 2025 alone.[4]

To gain deeper insight, several survey studies have endeavored to estimate the count and demographics of underage social media users through self-report measures, where minors can anonymously state their age, various background information, and whether and how they use different social platforms. The Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development Study (ABCD Study; Nagata et al., 2025), spanning dozens of researchers across several North American universities, collected data with a nationally representative, stratified sample of U.S. children between 11 and 15. They reported that just about two in three children between 11 and 13 indicated using social media, and that they signed up for about three platforms on average (typically including Tiktok, YouTube, Instagram, Snapchat, or Facebook). Only a small number of these children, roughly 5%, reported keeping their social media account secret from their parents; the other 95% stated, at least by implication, that their parents were aware.

[4] The company provided the cited number in response to a request for comment by news media agencies; see https://www.bbc.com/news/articles/cn48n18pg1eo (March 12, 2026).

Independent U.S. nonprofit organizations, including Pew Research Center and Common Sense Media, have reported similar numbers in their national surveys (see Table 1 below for a detailed overview).[5] They found that U.S. minors, including those under 13 (i.e., under the required age), are active on at least one if not multiple social media platforms. Notably, breaking down the data into finer-grained age increments reveals large variability in social media usage over the early years. For example, survey data from 2021 suggested about 41% of children between ages 8 and 12 are using social media platforms (Common Sense Media, 2021). In contrast, for children under age 8, their survey found that only 2% were using social media "at least once or more per day" (Common Sense Media, 2025). Put together, verified numbers on the exact number of underage users remain hard to come by; however, nationally representative self-report surveys paired with growing company transparency data[6] suggest that within the multi-billion user base across today's largest social media platforms, likely many million users are minors.

Critically, social media platforms do not just have vast user numbers among the youngest of age brackets, but minors reportedly spend notable amounts of time on them. For instance, the latest Pew Research Center data (2025) showed about three-quarters of 13- to 17-year-olds in the U.S. use social media "every day." For TikTok, for example, 21% of minors reported using the social media "almost constantly," 34% "several times a day," and 6% "about once a day," for a total of 61% of U.S. minors using the social media platform daily. Notably, the report showed that these numbers varied substantially across social media platforms; for instance, about 10% of minors in the same age bracket reported using Instagram and Facebook "almost constantly." The most recent

[5] Both organizations recruit minors and families by randomly sampling residential addresses across the country. Surveys are weighted to be representative by various factors (e.g., age, ethnicity, household income).
[6] See, e.g., Meta Transparency Reports (https://transparency.meta.com/reports/), Snapchat Transparency Reports (https://values.snap.com/privacy/transparency-h1-2025); TikTok Transparency Reports (https://www.tiktok.com/transparency/en).

Common Sense Media (2025) report indicated that 62% of 13- to 18-year-olds use social media every day, compared to 18% of 8- to 12-year-olds. Among the former group, the self-reported average duration of daily social media use was 1.5 hours. The 8- to 12-year-olds reported a much lower average of 18 minutes per day. Similarly, the ABCD Study's 11- to 13-year-olds reported using social media for an average of 19 minutes per day on a typical day.[7] Put together, the extent and duration of minors' social media use is certainly notable overall; however, there is substantial variability between platforms, between different age brackets, and, not least, between individuals.

Table 1. Selected Survey Results on U.S. Minors' Self-Reported Social Media Use by Age.

Survey	Reference	Time	Usage above age 13	Usage from ages 8-12	Usage under age 8
ABCD Study	Nagata et al. (2025)	2019-2021	• 69.5% of 13- to 15-year-olds have at least one account • Two thirds within the age group use TikTok, YouTube, and Instagram	• 63.8% of children report using social media • The average respondent has just over three social media accounts	N/A
Teen, Social Media, and AI Chatbots	Pew Research Center (2025)	Sep-Oct 2025	• Most 13- to 17-year-olds are registered on at least one social media platform • 75% of the YouTube users use the platform "every day"	N/A	N/A
The Common Sense Census: Media Use by Kids Zero to Eight	Common Sense Media (2025)	Aug 2024	N/A	N/A	• 2% of children use social media at least once a day • Roughly half have watched videos on YouTube, TikTok, or

[7] Studies have indicated that users tend to underestimate the duration of their digital technology use, including social media use, in self-report (e.g., Kaye et al., 2020). To my knowledge, no studies using objective measures of minors' social media use duration (e.g., screen time statistics or 'screenomic data'; see Ram et al., 2020) exist to date.

Survey	Reference	Time	Usage above age 13	Usage from ages 8-12	Usage under age 8
					Instagram Reels; 16% do so daily
The Common Sense Census: Media Use by Tweens and Teens	Common Sense Media (2021)	Sep-Oct 2021	N/A	• About one in three (38%) have used social media • Among users aged 8-12, 62% use social media "every day"	N/A
Children and Parents: Media Use and Attitudes Report	Ofcom UK (2025)	Oct-Nov 2024	• 96% of 13- to 17-year-olds use social media	• 55% of 3- to 12-year-olds use at least one social media platform	• 37% of 3- to 5-year-olds use at least one social media platform

Note. The above numbers represent aggregates; see original reports for full results. Social media use is not uniform, neither across ages 13 to 17 nor under 13. Self-reported use varied within younger and older age brackets and with other demographic factors (e.g., gender).

Concerns Around Minors' Social Media Use

Children and youth have clearly adopted social media into their lives, spending notable amounts of time on the platforms, both before and after reaching the minimum required age. What are the main concerns around this use? And who should be consulted on the question of what the harms of youths' social media use are? Insights on this question can, for one, be drawn from the users themselves: The minors who actively and regularly spend time on social media.

Decades of survey research by the Pew Research Institute have shown that minors willingly engage in discourse on possible harms and have specific things to say about their own social media use and its follow-ons. Drawing on the most recent nationwide surveys (Pew Research Institute, 2018; 2022; 2025), U.S. children and youth often emphasize social concerns (bullying, exclusion, peer pressure), time concerns (procrastination, neglect of other tasks), mental well-being concerns, and data privacy concerns (lack of control over data), among other things. For instance, in one of the

earliest nationwide surveys on modern social media use (Pew Research Institute, 2018), one in four and one in two 13- to 17-year-olds expressed overwhelm with drama or generally feeling worse about their own life, respectively. An interesting additional finding from the 2022 survey suggested that only 9% of 13- to 17-year-olds stated social media is "mostly negative" for themselves, but one third stated that social media use was "mostly negative" for *other* people their age. Similarly, the most recent Pew survey (2025) indicated that 48% 13- to 17-year-olds viewed social media use as "mostly negative" for their age group, and the same proportion reported spending "too much time on social media." Findings on the benefits of social media use were similarly consistent: Across all surveys since 2018, the underage respondents expressed appreciation for the ability to learn new things, connect with friends, meeting new people, and develop their personal interests. These benefits were avowed by up to two thirds of U.S. minors.

In addition to perspectives from the underage users themselves, academic researchers, legal experts, medical professionals (e.g., pediatricians, psychiatrists), policymakers, and the social media platform creators (executives, technical experts, designers) themselves have raised various possible risks. Table 2 provides a detailed breakdown of commonly mentioned candidates for harms and benefits as raised in the survey studies reviewed above in addition to behavioral research, court filings, and popular media. Listed alongside are the proposed main bearer and source of each harm and benefit. In summary, the main categories of concern are that social media use may negatively affect minors' physical well-being, mental and social well-being, safety, privacy, information diet, and financial well-being. The main benefits of minors' social media use include possible positive effects on personal development as well as mental and social well-being.

Table 2. Overview of potential risks, harms, and benefits of minors' social media use.

Category	Behavior or effect	Who bears the harm or benefit?			Source of harm or benefit		
		User	Intimates	Society	Passive use[a]	Active use[b]	Third party conduct
Potential harms and risks							
Physical well-being	Self-harm; suicide	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Sedentary lifestyle and associated risks[^]	X			X	X	
	Posture issues[^]	X			X	X	
	Eye strain[^]	X			X	X	
	Headaches[^]	X			X	X	
	Sleep deprivation	X			X	X	
	Time loss, reduced performance (e.g., school, work)	X		X	X	X	
Mental and social well-being	Compulsive use	X	X	X	X	X	
	Neglect of other activities (e.g., hobbies)	X	X	X	X	X	
	Harm to self-esteem	X			X	X	X
	Harm to reputation	X	X	X		X	X
	Anxiety	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Social disconnection; erosion of social skills	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Depression	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Attention fragmentation	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Eating disorders	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Body dysmorphia	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Suicidal ideation	X	X		X	X	X
Safety	Exposure to bullying, harassment, hate speech	X			X	X	X
	Exposure to sexually explicit content	X			X	X	X
	Exposure to illegal content	X	X		X	X	X
	Exposure to extreme content (e.g., violence)	X	X		X	X	X

Category	Behavior or effect	Who bears the harm or benefit?			Source of harm or benefit		
		User	Intimates	Society	Passive use[a]	Active use[b]	Third party conduct
	Sexualization	X	X		X	X	X
	Exploitation and coercion (e.g., grooming, catfishing)	X	X		X	X	X
Information diet	Norm distortion (e.g., risky behavior, substance use)	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Exposure to misinformation, disinformation	X	X	X	X	X	X
Privacy	Collection, use, or disclosure of personal information	X	X		X	X	X
	Stalking	X	X		X	X	X
	Doxxing	X	X		X	X	X
Financial well-being	Exposure to scams and/or deceptive marketing	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Exposure to gambling mechanisms	X	X	X		X	
Potential benefits							
Mental and social well-being	Social connectedness; sense of belonging	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Nurturing of friend and family relationships	X	X	X		X	X
	Stigma reduction (e.g., neurodiversity)	X	X	X		X	X
	Information-sharing; learning	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Entertainment; fun	X	X	X	X	X	X
	Relaxation; stress relief	X	X	X	X	X	X
Personal development	Opportunities to explore	X				X	
	Self-expression	X	X	X		X	
	Professional networking	X		X		X	
	Empowerment; civic engagement	X	X	X		X	

Note. [a]refers to passive engagement such as scrolling through or viewing content. [b]refers to active engagement such as creating and posting content. [^]These harms are tied to screen use and/or mobile phone use rather than (just) social media use itself; however, since social media can be accessed only via screens, they are included here. Table content compiled based on empirical literature reviews, company statements, media coverage, and public surveys (see References); table structure inspired by MacCoun et al. (1996).

Critically, the empirical debate regarding the harms, risks, and benefits of minors' social media use stands unsettled. The details of the related empirical evidence have been reviewed at length elsewhere (see, e.g., Agyapong-Opoku et al., 2025; Bozzola et al., 2022; Hancock et al., 2022; Schonning et al., 2020; Orben & Przybylski, 2019; Odgers & Jensen, 2020; Office of the Surgeon General, 2023; Valkenburg et al., 2022). In brief, there have been large-scale studies conducted across the West (Fassi et al., 2025; Orben et al., 2019; Orben, 2020, Orben et al., 2022), the Global South (Ghai et al., 2022), and Australia (Rice, 2016). However, the data are overwhelmingly correlational, often sampled from single countries, based on sparsely validated self-report measures, conflicting in their directionality, and/or indicatory only of small effects. Due to the recency of social media use as a phenomenon as well as practical hurdles (e.g., ethical concerns around inducing harms and cooperation with social media platforms being difficult and rare), there is a lack of (quasi-)experimental and longitudinal evidence on (a) the circumstances under which social media use is harmful, (b) the ways in which it is harmful, (c) for whom it is harmful (see Ghai et al., 2023, for a discussion on sample diversity), and (d), what the mechanisms causing the harm are (but see Orben et al., 2024, for a notable example). The evidence substantiating claims around potential benefits of youths' social media use, as raised by academics and social media companies, is equally sparse if not sparser (but see, e.g., National Academies Report, 2024).

In the absence of empirical studies, the potential risks and harms can also be quantified via data obtained and evaluated by social media platforms themselves. Both popular media and ongoing court cases have referenced various internal studies conducted by major social media platforms

such as Facebook and Instagram.[8] The related findings have been reviewed at length elsewhere[9]; in brief, the harms and risks raised by company employees and third-party reviewers again included mental and physical well-being (e.g., exacerbating anxiety and depressive symptoms) and safety (e.g., exposure to harassment), and the identified benefits pertained to social well-being (e.g., social connectedness) and self-development (e.g., self-expression). In summary, while conclusive evidence remains to be seen, this suggests there is at least notable agreement on the categories of potential harms, risks, and benefits across the relevant stakeholders, including the underage users, academic researchers, legal experts, medical professionals, policymakers, and even select social media platform employees.

The outlined harms, risks, and benefits are hypothesized to apply to children writ large. Given the conflicting evidence, research reviews from the last few years have begun making calls for investigations of how harmful outcomes may relate to markers of individual variability, such as mental health vulnerability (Orben et al., 2024). More generally, a crucial gap in the research literature as well as reports coming from the social media platforms themselves is to what degree different groups of minors may be affected, and what moderates susceptibility to various harms (see Beyens et al., 2020, for an example study on person-specific effects). One critical differentiating factor may be age-dependent developmental windows of sensitivity to social media (see Orben et al., 2022). The social media platforms referenced in this essay all hold Terms of Service requiring users to be age 13 or older to create an account on the main platform. Yet, as noted above, it is known that children do not wait until age 13 to log onto platforms. The Stanford

[8] For news coverage, see, e.g., https://www.nytimes.com/2026/01/16/podcasts/jonathan-haidt-new-evidence.html (New York Times, 2026); https://www.wsj.com/tech/personal-tech/facebook-knows-instagram-is-toxic-for-teen-girls-company-documents-show-11631620739 (Wall Street Journal, 2021).
[9] See https://metasinternalresearch.org/ for a comprehensive repository by Sippel et al. (2026).

Well-Being Project (see Stanford Youth Safety and Digital Wellbeing Report, 2025) is among the first empirical investigations of how use of digital tools and devices relates to well-being among children aged 9-13 in the United States. Further research with these younger groups is needed to better understand whether and how the impacts of social media use differ between younger and older developmental groups.

Another factor that may shape the harms and risks that underage users face are the platforms themselves. While platforms share basic features such as facilitating interaction among users and enabling them to create and share content (Boyd, 2014), they vary widely in their content algorithms, content moderation strategies, and general platform design, among other things. Understanding the nuances of harms, risks, and benefits includes understanding what works under the status quo and what does not; a systematic investigation of differences between platforms can provide further clues on what other platforms can do to prevent and mitigate harm (see, e.g., van der Wal, 2025, for a recent study).

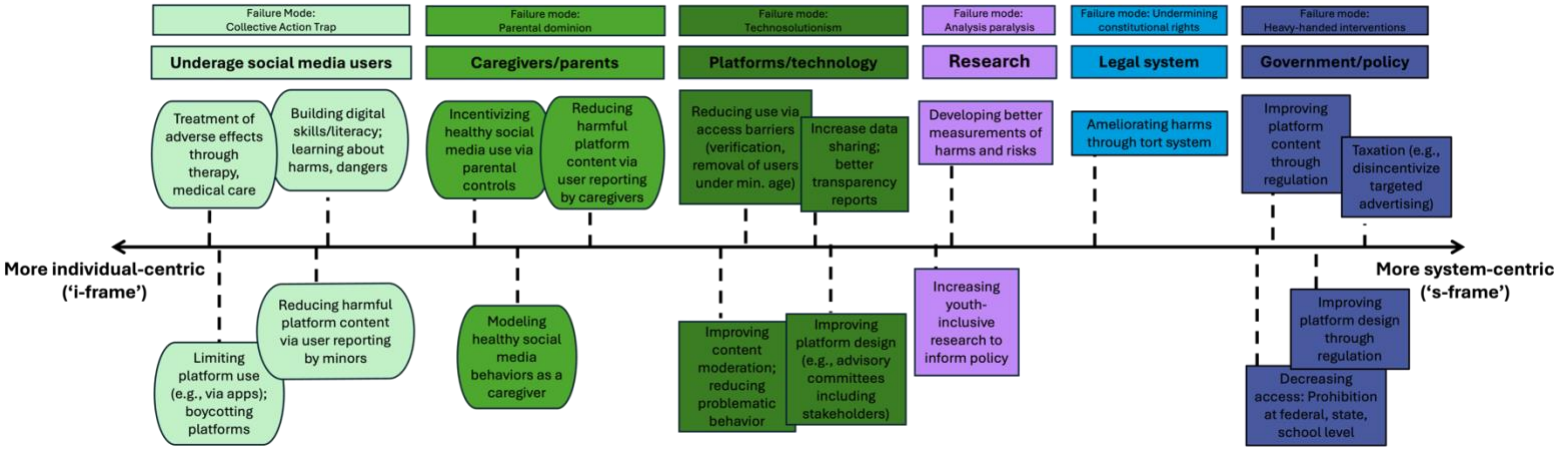
Alternatives for Strategy and Policy

The inconclusive state of evidence presents decisionmakers with a challenge: Do the potential harms and risks, as they stand, already warrant action? Which kinds of actions, interventions, and policy options may be best fit for addressing the potential harms and risks of minors' social media use? And by which evidentiary standards should alternatives be implemented and evaluated?

Skeggs and Orben (2025) conducted a literature review of intervention types relating to social media use, differentiating between five intervention focus points: (1) The social media platform (e.g., manipulating platform features), (2) the device (e.g., intervention apps), (3) the person or user (e.g., reducing use), (4) the family or close community (e.g., parental controls), and (5) society

(e.g., school phone bans). Building on these five focus points, Figure 3 provides a taxonomy of existing alternatives addressing the potential harms and risks of minors' social media use. These do not exclusively involve action at the policy level; there is a wide array of approaches that vary in the extent to which they are 'individual-centric' (i.e., no or little policy-level action) versus 'system-centric' (i.e., grounded in or directly related to policy-level action). Individual-centric alternatives are driven by an 'i-frame,' a primary focus on individuals' behaviors and thoughts, and how changes at the level of individuals can prevent or ameliorate the issue at hand. System-centric alternatives, in contrast, primarily focus on the systems and environments individuals are situated in, including the changes that can be effected through laws and policies (see Chater & Loewenstein, 2023, for a detailed discussion). In the present case, more 'individual-centric' alternatives lean more heavily on actions and changes on the end of minors and caregivers or parents, whereas more 'system-centric' alternatives lean more heavily on actions and changes on the side of social media companies, researchers, the legal system, and/or policy and government.

Figure 3. Taxonomy of Alternatives for Addressing Minors' Social Media Use.



Note. Inspired by Kilmer et al. (2024). Options are neither mutually exclusive nor necessarily independent; for instance, government policies (e.g., legally prohibiting social media access among minors) can shape platform/technology design, and platform/technology design can shape caregiver or parent behavior (e.g., by shifting the availability and use of parental controls).

Failure Modes of Alternatives

The ongoing public discourse has highlighted various failure modes for different alternatives relating to different focus points as highlighted in Figure 3. One noted failure mode related to a heavy focus on individual action by minors and caregivers is the 'collective action problem' (see, e.g., Rausch & Haidt. 2023). The collective action problem suggests that the ability of parents and minors to improve, adjust, or quit their social media use (e.g., restricting time on social media or improving minors' social media literacy) is dependent on whether other minors and parents in their social environment are aligned in their actions. The claim is that if surrounding minors and parents are *not* coordinated on their decision to also pursue change in their social media use, it is more challenging for a given individual minor and parent to do so. Relatedly, a heavy focus and reliance on parents to monitor and avoid possible harms and risks of their children's social media use may diminish minors' ability to make decisions for themselves and create 'parental dominion.' For instance, Benforado (2023) notes that, in general, a potential downstream consequence of heavy deference to parental authority is that parents become gatekeepers to children's relationships and social connectedness, which can lead to unwanted isolation on the minor's end.

Angel and Boyd (2024) note that a heavy focus on regulating platform access, content, and design presumes that the technology itself is the cause and solution for harm and problems among young people ('technosolutionism') as opposed to the symptom. They say an alternative possibility is that technology simply makes existing struggles visible rather than causing them; based on their case, implementing solutions at the platform level is misplaced and ineffective. Indeed, resolving this question of cause versus symptom would require gathering conclusive evidence. However, this is one possible failure mode of research. Public health scholars such as Benzian et al. (2026) point out that deferring critical decisions in wait for (more) certain evidence can create 'analysis

paralysis': A repeated delay in decisions due to inappropriately applied evidentiary standards. As for relying on resolving questions of social media's harms through the legal system, scholars (e.g., Angel & Boyd, 2024) and popular commentators[10] suggest has a failure mode lurking, too: Pursuing resolution through the legal system, such as holding technology companies liable for minors' well-being, may leave the underlying issue unresolved and make for a misguided attempt to protect minors' well-being at the cost of undermining constitutional rights to free speech. Last but not least, various literature has argued that market failure alone does not justify government intervention (see, e.g., Kleiman & Teles, 2008 for a review). Instead, heavy-handed government policy (such as prohibiting underage social media use at a federal or state level) should be pursued only in specific cases, such as when individual actors' voluntary action has clearly produced suboptimal results. Additionally, government effectiveness depends on many factors, including the cooperation of the affected groups; for instance, in the case of underage social media use, the evidence on social media use among children under 13 despite technically being barred from access suggests the problem may not be easily resolved by government interventions of such kind.

Implementation of Alternatives

Possible failure modes notwithstanding, in tandem with ongoing research, court cases, and public discussion, several sets of policymakers and governing bodies have already implemented various alternatives addressing minors' social media use. For instance, as of December 2025, Australia put a 'social media ban' in effect for its minors under age 16, whereby children and youth under the specified age can neither keep nor create accounts on the most popular social media platforms.[11] This represents a system-centric approach: Enacting a policy that changes minors' environment

[10] See, e,g., French (2026): https://www.nytimes.com/2026/03/29/opinion/free-speech-social-media-court-ruling.html
[11] See, e.g., https://www.unicef.org.au/unicef-youth/staying-safe-online/social-media-ban-explainer (2025)

(i.e., legislation and platforms) so that it fully prohibits access to the social media content and design that is potentially harmful. In 2022 and 2023, the United Kingdom and European Union passed the UK Online Safety Act and EU Digital Services Act, respectively, both of which targeted the regulation of platform design features and minors' access to and protection from specific platform content.[12] Similarly, in the United States, several policy bills have established principles for social media platform design that aim to protect users' data, help counteract compulsive use, and enable parent controls (UNICEF, 2026; e.g., Vermont Age-Appropriate Design Code Act, SB69; Nebraska Age-Appropriate Online Design Code Act, LB504). Ongoing research studies conducted by researchers at the University of Pennsylvania collaborate with local schools to test school-wide smartphone bans (see, e.g., Duckworth et al., in progress).[13] Emerging research is also developing new validated measures for assessing healthy versus harmful social media use among minors (e.g., the 'Tech With Care Index For Teens'; Konrath et al., 2025). U.S. public health organizations such as the American Academy of Pediatrics have also released general guidelines for caregivers and families, such as the '5 Cs of Media Use'.[14]

Additionally, just last year, new studies presented some of the first-ever large-scale experimental evidence on user-centric social media interventions. For instance, Hoong (2025) partnered with a leading social media platform to test Digital Wellness Alarms with 13 million users, reporting that, on average, the alarms reduced their usage by about 5 minutes (about one-tenth of users' baseline duration of use). Unfortunately, this initial report[15] did not yet analyze how a reduction in use relates to well-being or various facets of harm and risk (cf. Table 2). It also leaves unclear how

[12] https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/online-safety-act-explainer/online-safety-act-explainer; https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/digital-services-act
[13] https://knowledge.wharton.upenn.edu/article/do-school-cell-phone-bans-help-students-do-better/
[14] https://www.aap.org/en/patient-care/media-and-children/center-of-excellence-on-social-media-and-youth-mental-health/5cs-of-media-use/
[15] This study is currently ongoing.

many of the users in the sample were underage, and thus cannot elucidate potential beneficial effects for younger age groups; interventions that may benefit and/or protect underage social media users remain a critical gap in the literature to date. Nevertheless, this project represents an unprecedented improvement in the scale and quality of evidence that academic researchers can obtain, and may signal a shift in companies' readiness to collaborate with scientists in the testing of interventions. In sum, albeit far from conclusive, evidence, guidelines, and frameworks for various alternatives addressing minors' social media use are continuing to accumulate in real time.

Evidentiary Standards and Frameworks for Alternatives

While evidence and guidelines are still accumulating, select policymakers and governing bodies have determined that the potential harms and risks, as they stand, already warrant action. Different kinds of actions, interventions, and policy options have been pursued to address the potential harms of minors' social media use. By which standards should they be implemented and evaluated?

For one, decision-makers and stakeholders can consider evidentiary standards. To date, the question of evidentiary standards has been spoken on by at least two camps. The first camp asserts that the stakes in this matter are high and that precautionary measures should be taken even if scientific evidence is still uncertain (cf. 'precautionary principle'; Foster et al., 2000). In the matter of social media policy, proponents of this stance may (although not necessarily) argue in favor of heavy-handed regulation such as prohibiting children and youth from using social media entirely, and that these policies should be put in place until research has produced strong *negative* evidence of its harms (i.e., strong evidence that there are no harms to minors' social media use). This position has been prominently represented by Jonathan Haidt, Jean Twenge, and others, as the quote below illustrates (see also Haidt, 2024; Twenge, 2017):

"[…] when we get to, say, 60 percent or 70 percent of kids actually being off [social media] — and the effectiveness matters; this is a cat-and-mouse game, so the companies are going to have to up their game — but once we get to, say, 70 percent of kids actually being off, now we've broken the collective-action trap. Now kids can be off. Now parents can say "no" more easily. And once we get there, I think within a year we'll start seeing lots of reports of different behavior. […] if we don't see anything budge in five years, I would then have to conclude that I was wrong in thinking that reducing social media use would improve mental health. But here's the thing: This whole debate has been framed around mental health. And if it doesn't improve mental health, does that mean we should undo it? I would say no" (New York Times, 2026).[16]

The opposing camp counters that regulation, particularly heavy-handed regulation such as prohibition of access for all minors, should not be put in place until there is strong *positive* evidence of harm; i.e., strong evidence that there are clear harms to minors' social media use, with establishment of cause-and-effect. This position has been carried by or, at minimum, alluded to by technology companies, including social media companies (cf. the 'innovation-first' regulatory standard; Atkinson, 2019).

Notably, proponents of the above positions not only vary in their evidentiary standards, but also in their interpretation of existing evidence. Haidt, for instance, argues that the evidence outlining the negative impact of this use, particularly per the companies' own internal studies, is clear and exceedingly worrisome (see Haidt, 2024; https://metasinternalresearch.org/). In contrast, referring to the same evidence, companies operating social media platforms, including Meta executive Mark Zuckerberg, have stated that "Mental health is a complex issue, and the existing body of scientific

[16] See https://www.nytimes.com/2026/01/16/podcasts/jonathan-haidt-new-evidence.html for full interview transcript.

work has not shown a causal link between using social media and young people having worse mental health outcomes." (Zuckerberg, U.S. Senate Hearing, 2024, p. 1)[17, 18] In sum, disagreement about evidentiary standards as well as the interpretation of the existing evidence still abounds.

Separate from evidentiary standards, decision-makers and stakeholders can consider values. Values are things stakeholders and decision-makers determine to hold weight (Perlmutter et al., 2024); they can be complementary to empirical evidence but are, at least in principle, independent. Critically, values can be factored into high-stakes questions even when answers are unknown. In the present matter, a highly relevant set of values is instantiated in the United Nations Convention of the Rights of the Child (UNCRC, 1989; see https://www.unicef.org/child-rights-convention). This convention was developed by global policymakers and domain experts from a wide range of backgrounds. The UNCRC's primary purpose is to protect and safeguard children's rights, interests, and development; most critically, the Convention was supported and signed by all UN member states except for the United States. Its contents, including the values it reflects, are therefore widely agreed upon; it is among the most widely ratified treaties in history. Table 3 provides an outline of key values and rights from the UNCRC applied to three alternatives drawn from the taxonomy in Figure 3: Prohibition, (more) child-appropriate platform design, and the nurturing of minors' social media use skills. These alternatives were chosen for illustration as they represent alternatives along different points on the 'i-frame' to 's-frame' spectrum.

[17] See https://www.judiciary.senate.gov/imo/media/doc/2024-01-31_-_testimony_-_zuckerberg.pdf for full transcript.
[18] See also https://www.meta.com/safety/teen/ for Meta's public statement on the empirical research.

Table 3. Comparison of Values and Rights Under Three Different Alternatives for Addressing Minors' Social Media Use.

	Status Quo[19]		**Option 1: Barring or restricting minors from social media access**		**Option 2: Nurturing minors' social media use skills**		**Option 3: (More) child-appropriate design on platforms**	
Main focus	Unclear		Prevention		Education, treatment		Prevention	
Time horizon	Short term	Long term	Short term	Long term	Short term	Long term	Short term	Long term
Privacy	-	-	+	+	?	?	+	+
Security	-	-	+	+	+	+	+	+
Non-discrimination	+	+	-	?	?	?	+	+
Rights to life and best possible development	-	-	?	?	+	+	?	+
Access to information	+	+	-	-	+	+	+	+
Freedom of thought, sharing thoughts freely	+	+	-	-	+	+	+	+
Respect for views	?	?	-	-	?	?	?	+
Setting up and joining groups	+	+	-	-	+	+	+	+
Protection from violence, harm, abuse, exploitation	-	-	+	+	+	+	+	+
Take part in play, culture, arts	?	?	-	+	+	+	+	+
Political Feasability	-		High		Unclear		-	
Company Feasability	High		High		Unclear		High	

Note. '+' denotes positive result or change; '-' denotes negative result or change; '?' denotes unclear result or change. Values and rights were derived from the UN Convention on the Rights of the Child as well as Goodyear et al. (2025). The listed policy options are not mutually exclusive.

While the UNCRC is legally binding for its member states, it does not specify the details of how related policy or legislation should be implemented; this allows national government bodies and

[19] Current policy varies by country; for simplicity, here, this refers only to the United States without accounting for state-level differences.

legislators to pursue various means. The UK Online Safety Act (2023) and EU Digital Services Act (2022) provide two modern-day examples of policies relating to minors' online presence that build on UNCRC principles. Importantly, this framework accounts not only for potential impacts on children and youth as key stakeholders, but also highlights important aspects of their rights, development, and perspectives as individuals. Organizations such as the Pew Research Center (2023) have questioned youth specifically on their perspectives on social media policy. Their results showed that about half of the surveyed 13- and 17-year-olds in the U.S. favored some of the most commonly proposed options for addressing harmful social media use, such as parental controls, time limits on social media use, and age verification mechanisms. About 70 to 80% of U.S. adults endorsed those same alternatives. Notably, however, this survey study is one among only a handful of attempts to directly solicit children and youth's perspectives on how decision-makers should proceed in the issue at hand.

Proposals for Moving Forward

The previous sections of this work outline that there is notable agreement on the potential risks and harms of minors' social media use, and that suggested options and alternatives for addressing the issue abound. Still, related evidence, shared interpretations of existing evidence, and alignment on evidentiary standards are lacking. What other steps can be taken to move this issue forward?

An increasingly highlighted approach to policy issues affecting minors is the direct inclusion of children's and youths' perspectives ('youth-inclusive policy'). In brief, this involves soliciting their opinions, ideally at scale, and formally including them in policy discussions. Decision-makers and policymakers in the U.S. and internationally are already forming task forces to shape social media policy that can substantially shape minors' lives. Given this, countries other than the U.S.

are actively pursuing youth-inclusive policy: A report by UNICEF (2026)[20] documented that, for instance, in 2024, the Canadian Government funded and reviewed a survey with over 1,000 children between the ages of 14 and 17 on their online experiences, including their perspectives on social media platforms (Lockhart et al., 2024). Similarly, the Australian government consulted over 200 children between 8 and 17 in navigating online privacy issues. According to the UNICEF report, UNICEF Innocenti also conducted a survey with 10- to 17-year-old children, including U.S. nationals, to seek out what they see as their best interests in digital spaces such as social media. Similarly, as reviewed above, various local non-profit organizations (e.g., Pew Research Center, Common Sense Media) have surveyed U.S. minors. Yet, there is no documented inclusion of these data and perspectives in local, state-level, or federal initiatives in the U.S., and to my knowledge, no U.S. officials have reported youth-inclusive methods in their social media policy.

While youth-inclusive policy is not without its challenges (e.g., establishing principles for fair representation of various children and youth), it is a critical and promising step in developing measures and next steps in the United States. For one, minors are already spearheading litigation against social media companies in the U.S. (see, e.g., *K.G.M v Meta* and MDL No. 3047)[21] and actively participating in expressing what they perceive as the primary harms and risks of their social media use. Youth-inclusive policies promise to lead not only to more inclusion of children but also better, more innovative policies (Helsper et al., 2025). Second, as outlined in the Introduction, children and youth are among the most ardent adopters of the technologies under discussion, which makes their first-hand insights uniquely helpful to be learned from. Third, in line with the UNCRC, UN member states all around the world agree that children have a right to

[20] See https://www.unicef.org/innocenti/stories/evolving-digital-landscape-and-best-interests-child.
[21] https://www.motleyrice.com/social-media-lawsuits/meta and https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/K.G.M._v._Meta_et_al.

be heard, especially on issues that may harm them or deny them opportunities, which includes social media policy. Finally, youth-inclusive policy is especially promising in its independence from how the evidence base relating to harms and risks of minors' social use further develops. Indeed, empirical data may continue to yield inconclusive results; however, if a substantial proportion of U.S. minors nevertheless voice a desire for specific changes in social media policy and design, this can help substantially inform decision-making under an uncertain evidence base.

A second set of approaches that can directly contribute to resolving the current tensions over the evidentiary standards and interpretation of evidence is the well-established research practice of adversarial collaborations (see Clark & Tetlock, 2023). In brief, adversarial collaborations involve the collaboration scholars of opposing views (see, e.g., Haidt, 2024, and Odgers, 2024, in response to Haidt, 2024). The two parties outline and address the strongest version of the opposite argument; they then design a study or series of studies addressing the question using mutually agreed upon methods (e.g., is excessive social media use harmful to minors' mental health?); they next agree on the mode of data collection (e.g., by a neutral third party); finally, they commit to publishing results regardless of which (if any) position the results align with. To my knowledge, while scholars studying the harms, risks, and benefits have certainly responded to other studies with rebuttal articles and conducted re-analyses of other datasets (see, e.g., the adversarial review by Meier & Krause, 2023), none have pursued an adversarial collaboration to date. The adoption of this method can give the current discourse a significant push, not only to the benefit of policy-makers and the minors in need, but also to the benefit of social media research itself.

Conclusion

Social media platforms have exploded in popularity and use, and children and youth are among their most ardent users, likely counting millions in the United States alone. Just within the last five years, social media-related concerns, policy changes, and litigation have grown alongside minors' use of social media. The ruling of March 25, 2026, demonstrated that the discussion around minors' social media use is supremely high-stakes, steadily developing, and complex in substance and solution-finding. Empirical evidence speaking to the harms, risks, and benefits of underage people's engagement with social media platforms remains hotly debated and largely inconclusive. However, various stakeholders, including the minors themselves, as well as caregivers, educators, academics, legal experts, medical professionals, policymakers, political leaders, and tech workers, are converging on concerns about potential negative effects for minors' physical and mental well-being, safety, and privacy in particular.

Still, many key questions remain on the table: Do the potential harms and risks, as they stand, already warrant action? Which kinds of actions, interventions, and policy options may be best fit for addressing the potential harms and risks of minors' social media use? And by which evidentiary standards should alternatives be implemented and evaluated? How can we proceed from here?

The present work highlighted that today, policies and practices adopted by various countries around the world take on a range of points of focus, ranging from focusing on the behaviors and thinking of underage social media users as individuals, their caregivers and parents, the design and content of social media platforms, research practices, harm compensation in the legal system, and policy passed by government. Existing alternatives were summarized in a taxonomy and then reviewed in their implementation, failure modes, and related evidentiary standards. Additionally,

two proposals for constructive next steps were introduced: Avenues and arguments for youth-inclusive social media policy, and the notable potential of adversarial collaboration to make headway on the interpretation of evidence in evaluating social media's harms and risks for minors.

The present treatment was not exhaustive in nature. For one, this work did not address the much-discussed question of social media addiction and its relation to when and how social media use may be harmful for minors or users writ large. Secondly, social media platforms have already pursued and implemented various platform changes relating to content, design, and safety over the years. A more in-depth systematic review and evaluation of different platform-level changes and their effectiveness can help clarify what solutions and safeguards the private sector has (not) already pursued. These insights, in turn, can speak directly to the question of whether and how policy and individual-level interventions are needed over and above changes on the side of the social media companies. Third, the present work does not include a systematic review of the hundreds of ongoing civil litigation cases related to minors' social media use. Future work may seek to include a more comprehensive analysis of existing legal strategies. Such an analysis can speak to the most and least successful arguments on where the harms and responsibilities lay in the matter of minors' social media use while evidence is still developing.

In closing, it is worth noting that, in tandem with the social media policy questions discussed here, discourse over the potential harms and risks of children's and youth's AI use has been growing over recent years. The discussions in the area of minors' AI use and minors' social media is overlapping and could be mutually informative. Perhaps more than ever, U.S. policy responses to these unprecedentedly rapid developments in technology will benefit from cross-sector collaboration, inclusive approaches, and evidence-informed decision-making that heeds the rights and perspectives of minors.

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